

The Swan Children's Lullaby

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, a wise old salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with cleverness and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.



The Swan Children's Lullaby

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

For as long as anyone in the village could remember, four white swans had sung a lullaby over the Misty Loch each dusk. Their song lifted the evening mist and turned the whole sky to rose and gold, and the village settled to sleep beneath it. But this evening the song faltered. It wavered, lost its way, and forgot its own tune halfway through. A heavy grey mist crept up off the water and settled over the loch and the rooftops, and no one could find the sunset behind it.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver called the two of you to her side by the warm hearth of the Roundhouse. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more than a loud voice tonight. Will you go down to the loch and help the swan children remember their lullaby, so the mist lifts again?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: the little harp, worn smooth with playing, a sprig of oak for luck, and a honey oatcake wrapped in a leaf. "Remember," she said, "here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Cleverness, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1: The Grey Mist

The path led you down to the loch, where the mist hung so thick and grey that the water had all but vanished. Somewhere out in that softness drifted the four swan children, but the mist had made them quiet and shy, and not a feather showed.

How will you find them without frightening them away? You might stand quite still and listen for the smallest ripple. You might call out, softly and kindly, so they know a friend has come. What do you try?

When you moved gently and spoke kindly, four pale shapes came gliding out of the mist towards you: four white swans with long necks and soft, sorrowful eyes. They had been waiting, it seemed, for someone with a kind face. They drew close and let you sit beside the water with them.

Stop 2: Remembering the Lullaby

The swan children longed to sing, but the lullaby had slipped away from them. The words had come loose and jumbled, and three small verses now drifted in the mist all out of order. Until the verses went back the right way, the song simply would not hold together.

A playful shape rustled in a nearby oak: Pook the Puca, the shapeshifting faerie, who loved a puzzle as much as a prank. He tipped you a wink and offered a small, sideways hint.

Can you help them piece the lullaby back together? Listen to each verse in turn. Think about which one begins the song and which one ends it. Talk it through together, and trust the picture the words paint.

When you set the three verses in their proper order, the swan children's eyes shone. "Yes, that is it," they breathed. "That is exactly how it goes." The shape of the song came back to them like a half-remembered dream.

Stop 3: Playing It Together

Now the swan children knew every word, and yet they hesitated. They were shy of their own voices, and the smallest swan was shyest of all. She opened her beak to begin, but no sound came, and she tucked her head beneath her wing, afraid to sing alone.

This was never a fight. How could you help her find her courage? You carry the little harp. You might play a slow, gentle tune to lead them in. You might tell the shyest swan that she is not alone, and sing along beside her so that no one has to begin by themselves. What do you do?

When you lifted the little harp and began to play, and your own voices joined the tune, the shyest swan slowly raised her head. A single sweet note slipped free, then another, growing braver with each breath. One by one the others joined her, until all four swan children were singing together, clear and strong and unafraid.

The Dusk Turns Rose

The lullaby rose over the Misty Loch the way it always had, and the heavy grey mist began to soften and to thin. Bit by bit it melted away, and in its place the dusk turned a deep and glowing rose, shot through with gold, until the whole loch held the sunset like a mirror.

On the green rise above, the Ring of Standing Stones hummed along, low and content, as it does whenever the swan children sing. The four swans glided in a slow circle, their song pouring out across the water. And high over the loch, Danu the Kind looked down on all of it and smiled.

You had done it, and you had done it together: with your cleverness, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Goodnight, heroes of the Emerald Isles. Sleep well.

The Story in Pictures



Two small heroes gently approaching four white swans gathered on a still grey misty loch at dusk.



Two small heroes and four white swans piecing a forgotten lullaby back together, soft glints of rose and gold returning to the dusk.



A small hero playing a little harp on a misty loch shore as four white swans sing along, the grey mist beginning to lift and glow.



A misty loch dusk turned rose and gold as four white swans sing, an ancient ring of standing stones glowing on a green rise, two heroes watching in wonder.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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